

Promoting ideas for change

Unless you are a top manager in your organization, chances are that you will need to “sell” your ideas for change at some point. Maybe you are an entrepreneur pitching an idea to a potential investor, or you have a great idea about how to make things work more efficiently in your organization. In either case, you will need support if your idea is to become a reality.

Making the business case

Whatever the starting point, the destination will be the same: you need to convince someone else that your idea is great and that it will work, and that they will get their investment (of time and money) back. And they need to believe in you and your capacity to deliver all of this. The problem is that you believing in your idea is unlikely to be enough—you need to put together a compelling business case to convince others that your idea has practical potential.



TIP

REHEARSE YOUR PITCH

Practice “selling” your idea to others, inviting critical comments and suggestions for how to improve it. Anticipating the big questions before you make the pitch to decision-makers will help ensure your message gets across.

Gaining support

Organizations need to innovate, but they cannot do everything. They need to explore options and then make tough decisions about which ideas they will back and why. You can influence these decisions to your advantage—if you know your organization is trying to put together a portfolio of projects that balances risk and reward, you can try and make them include yours in the mix. But you need to present your idea in such a way that its merits are clear. Ask yourself how you can engage them—can you show them a prototype so they can add their comments? Do you have the answers to questions they might ask you? And do you come across as being passionate about the project—will they believe in you?